Cholera

In 1854 London was suffering from an outbreak of cholera, a deadly disease. Nobody knew how the disease was spread. At that time, people had to get their water from pumps in the street. John Snow wondered if cholera was being spread by contaminated water. He made a map showing where the cases of cholera were occurring, and discovered that most cases were around Broad Street. John Snow broke the handle off the Broad Street pump so nobody could pump drinking water from it.

London's drinking water came from pools in underground beds of gravel or from underground streams. Sewage had leaked into the water, spreading cholera. John Snow is now known as the Father of Epidemiology (the study of the spread of disease). He saved dozens of lives.

☞ **1** How can natural disasters (for example, floods, cyclones, earthquakes, tsunamis) lead to cholera outbreaks?

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2 Military Response teams and organisations such as the Red Cross often rush to disaster zones with supplies of clean drinking water. Why?

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In modern times when a nation reports an **epidemic**, large scale international teamwork between doctors and governments takes place to control the disease. Disease outbreaks such as SARS are controlled by international cooperation.

☞ **3** Write down four things you think governments might do to control an international disease outbreak.

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